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Veiled sentiments

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Marriage, Divorce, and Polygyny

The loves of youth, fulfilled or unfulfilled, pass. Individuals have to face different kinds of crises in love once they have married, settled down, and begun their adult lives. Most Awlad ‘Ali marry fairly young—girls between about fifteen and twenty, boys anywhere between sixteen and thirty, depending on their financial situations. Many first marriages do not last but break up within a few months to a year because of youthful incompatibility or inlaw difficulties; most people remain with their second partners.

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The behavior and attitudes of spouses toward one another are powerfully shaped by the cultural ideals of modesty. Even if over time a married couple develop attachments, they rarely display their affection publicly. They spend little time together and do not engage in extended conversation, share meals, or work side by side. They politely avoid talking about each other in conversations with others, and they do not utter each other’s names. When men and women do make statements about their spouses or their marriages, they tend to express a limited range and special type of sentiment. At best they offer protestations of indifference or assertions of emotional independence. Women make jokes to suggest detachment from and lack of interest in their husbands. In situations of marital conflict, hostile insults and

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bitter complaints do surface, but these are always couched in material rather than emotional terms and justified by appeals to rights and duties.

Others reinforce these standards partly through teasing. I was surprised by the reception given a young woman who came running to one household crying. Shortly before, her husband had decided to take her back after "leaving" her (no longer going to sleep in her room) for two years. Now he was giving her a hard time about her chickens, which he said were messing the house; he wanted her to get rid of them. But she had been raising them for years and had used them to support her children. The women to whom she complained all concurred with one old woman who [■223](#) asked, "Why did you agree to go back to him? What do you want with a man? Your chickens are worth more than a husband."

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